

TIGER-EYE: Anand stuck to his campaign despite arbitrary rules his peers. But he was excluded and bypassed in the closed-door negotiations for reunification. The agreement, subsequently, broke down.

Anand's next chance came in 2005, after Kasparov had retired to lead a political alliance, The Other Russia, against President Vladimir Putin. FIDE held a title tournament in San Luis Rey, Argentina, where Topalov staged a great performance and finished ahead of Anand. There were persistent rumours that Topalov had cheated by accessing computer-analysis in play.

The obstacles that Anand had to work through were best illustrated by the 2006 Topalov-Kramnik 'unification' match sponsored by FIDE President Kirsan Ilyumzhinov, who is also the president of the Republic of Kalmykia, a tiny Buddhist enclave deep inside Russia. The match was held in Elista, the capital of Kalmykia and both Topalov and Kramnik had worked out quid pro quos before agreeing to play. Both men wanted another crack at the title without having to qualify. The Bulgarian President guaranteed the cash for any match involving Topalov. Backed by Putin and RCF officials, it was clear that 'Nas-Volodya' (Our Vladimir) would also not have a problem with funding. This arbitrary tilt in the playing field led the normally diplomatic Anand to say a few bitter things in public. But then he shrugged his shoulders. "FIDE can do what it likes and change the rules as it pleases. All I can do is ignore this and keep playing chess."

The extra motivation may just have been the spur required to take his game to another level. When Elista ended, with Kramnik winning a tie break, Anand was one of a triumvirate of players with serious title aspirations. The other two had money and negotiating clout. He just had skills. Between Elista and Mexico, Anand hit No. 1 and increased the distance between himself and the Nos. 2 and 3. In six months post Elista he won almost every game he played—and also prepared himself for the all important showdown in Mexico.

In the feel-good following Mexico, it is easy to forget that the pre-conditions



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tions to the event were absurdly imbalanced. The eight top players meet in a double round-robin. The Winner of Mexico (wom) is world champion. If the wom is Kramnik, he defends the title against Topalov in 2008. If wom is not Kramnik, he plays the wom in 2008 for the title. If the wom beats Kramnik in 2008, then he must meet

Topalov. If the wom loses either of these matches, he goes back to qualifiers for the next cycle. Unlike the other two, Anand had just one chance. He took it and emerged undefeated. With just three rounds to go, the title was almost mathematically secure but he was superstitious enough to duck meeting people lest they jinx him with premature congratulations. A determined defence of an inferior position in the pentultimate round against Russian Alexander Grischuk sealed the issue. A last-round draw against Hungarian Peter Leko was a formality.

Next year Anand will have to start defending his title. Please note 'start'. If he maintains the same motivation he showed during the past year, he should dominate upcoming matches the same way he dominated Mexico. Much has been written (especially in the East European press) about the lack of spirit and ambition of the 'Indian Tiger'. But the journey from Elista to Mexico has changed all that.

ROLL OF HONOUR

India's other world champions

BILLIARDS: Wilson Jones (1958, 1964) Michael Ferreira (1977, 1981, 1983) Geet Sethi (1985, 1987, 1992, 1993, 1995, 1998, 2001, 2006), Manoj Kothari (1990), Ashok Shandilya (2002), Pankaj Advani (2005, 2007)

SNOOKER: O.B. Agrawal (1984), Pankaj Advani (2003)

SHOOTING: Abhinav Bindra (2006), Manavjit Singh Sandhu (2006)

WEIGHTLIFTING: Karnam Malleswari (1994, 1995)

BOXING: M.C. Mary Kom (2002, 2005, 2006) Sarita Devi, Jenny R.L., K.C. Lekha (all 2006)

Former chess player Devangshu Datta is working with Viswanathan Anand on his autobiography.